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**Letter of Reference for SeriousShea to support fundraising for its “Zero Carbon, Zero Deforestation Value Chain”**

Geneva, 16 November 2021

To whom it may concern,

In June 2021, [1t.org](https://1t.org) and the World Economic Forum have selected William Kwende and SeriousShea as one of the winners of the UpLink Innovation Challenge [Trillion Trees: Sahel and the Great Green Wall](#) – a call for ecopreneurial approaches to landscape restoration that contribute to the vision of the Great Green Wall Initiative and deliver benefits to people and environment of the Sahel.

SeriousShea was selected by a high-level expert review panel as 1 out of 12 winning cohort members – out of a pool of 80 applicants – based on the organisation’s mission to protect existing trees and forests of the Great Green Wall and avoid deforestation by developing a value chain around Shea, its strong business plan with good financial projections and its partnership approach linking up various partners. Moreover, William Kwende has continuously impressed our team with the knowledge, dynamism and business acumen he brought to 1t.org’s engagement programme for challenge winners.

I therefore highly recommend SeriousShea and believe that additional funding would enable the organisation to further scale up their work and impact in Burkina Faso.

With best regards,



Nicole Schwab  
Co-Director, Platform to Accelerate Nature Based Solutions & 1t.org  
World Economic Forum